



Juste avant la nuit Just before Nightfall

Director: Claude Chabrol

Production Companies: Les Films la Boétie,
Paris Columbia Films, Cinemar (Rome)

Producer: André Génovès

Production Manager: Irénée Leriche

Assistant Directors: Patrick Saglio, Michel Dupuy

Screenplay: Claude Chabrol

Based on the novel by: Edward Atiyah

Director of Photography: Jean Rabier

Editor: Jacques Gaillard

Art Director: Guy Littaye

Music: Pierre Jansen

Sound: Guy Chichignoud, Alex Pront

Cast:

Stéphane Audran (*Hélène Masson*)

Michel Bouquet (*Charles Masson*)

François Périer (*François Tellier*)

Anna Douking (*Laura Tellier*)

Dominique Zardi

(*Dominique Prince*, agency colleague)

Marina Ninchi (*Gina Maillardi*, *Telliers' housekeeper*)

Henri Attal (*Police Officer Cavanna*)

Jean Carmet (*Jeannot*)

Daniel Lecourtois (*Dorfmann*)

Clelia Matania (*Charles' mother*)

Pascal Gillot (*Auguste Masson*)

Brigitte Périn (*Joséphine Masson*)

Célia (*Jacqueline*)

Paul Temps (*Bardin*, agency accountant)

Marcel Gassouk (*barman*)

Sylvie Lenoir (*barmaid*)

Roger Lumont (*Commissaire Delfeil*)

Michel Duchaussoy (*man at funeral*)

France-Italy 1971

108 mins

Digital (restoration)

Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Juste avant la nuit

SPOILER WARNING The following notes give away some of the plot.

The bourgeoisie survives on guilty secrets and its own discreet charm; the masochist craves public humiliation as the ultimate affirmation, and consummation, of his own self-hatred. Chabrol's *Juste avant la nuit* is the drama of a middle-class masochist, robbed by the society of which he is outwardly a symbol of both his crime and, to a lesser extent, his punishment. It is also the drama of an unfaithful husband, and as such something of a companion piece to *La Femme infidèle*.

Once again, Michel Bouquet's Charles enjoys an 'ideal' marriage with Stéphane Audran's Hélène in the insulated affluence of the Versailles green belt; once again, he murders the outsider who threatens their domestic equilibrium, and in the process betrays the violence of a passionate nature normally concealed by well-oiled social banalities. But where the faithful husband murdered his wife's lover in an excess of conjugal tenderness which revived her love for him, the crime of the adulterous Charles is open to more cynical interpretations. He strangles his depraved mistress in an attempt to deny his own depravity, yet in the act experiences a pleasure which he cannot attain with his superficially gentle and all-forgiving wife. And though Charles eventually moves Hélène to silent complicity in his crime, even forcing her to become his executioner, Chabrol here seems less concerned with the transference of guilt than with the considerably more repressive transference of innocence: the extremes to which the bourgeoisie will go to whitewash the cracks in its clean façade.

Charles' twofold guilt – his perversion and his crime – is established in the pre-credits sequence, with the camera tilting down a cramped and airless Paris street before zooming slowly in on a single window in a shot which recalls the illicit assignation at the opening of *Psycho*. In the room beyond, a fully dressed Michel Bouquet sits primly in the foreground, while behind him a woman, naked except for a holy medal at her throat, postures obscenely on a big, blue-sheeted bed (always a sign of sensuality in Chabrol's films) and orders, 'Viens jouer, ou je me venge.' The game which follows – a bizarre, sado-masochistic ritual in which the clearly dominant woman plays at being a naughty schoolgirl and demands punishment from 'monsieur le rapiste' – culminates in the strangling.

After the crime and the credits, Charles Masson repairs to a dimly lit bar where, despite his dark glasses, he is recognised by a surprised neighbour, François, who offers him a lift home. They stop for another drink in their friendly neighbourhood café – all bonhomie and sparkling primrose plastic – and the ugly new autoroute which has brought them out of Paris emerges as a bridge between two artificially separated worlds: the city of darkness, commerce and sordid sexuality; and the clean, green suburb, a kind of monument to man's moral pretensions. Here the film's ironies multiply. François is revealed not only as Charles' best friend and the husband of the murdered Laura, but also as the architect of Charles' house. Deprecating about his own marriage, he idealises that of the Massons and has built their house in his image of them: open-plan and made predominantly of glass, it is not a place for secrets. Nor, with its neat twin beds, is it a place for sensual discoveries. (Significantly, this is the one Chabrol film in which the characters eat little, and badly.) For Charles, the

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Claude Chabrol: Elements of Crime

Le Beau Serge

Thu 3 Sep 21:00; Sun 20 Sep 15:15 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze)

La Rupture

Fri 4 Sep 18:10; Sat 19 Sep 12:20; Sat 3 Oct 12:10
A double tour Web of Passion

Sat 5 Sep 14:30; Sat 19 Sep 14:50

The Third Lover

L'oeil du malin
Sat 5 Sep 18:20; Sat 19 Sep 20:45

The Beast Must Die

Que la bête meure
Sat 5 Sep 20:20; Thu 17 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by critic, lecturer and programmer Geoff Andrew);
Sun 4 Oct 18:10

Les Biches

Sun 6 Sep 18:30; Wed 23 Sep 20:40;
Sun 27 Sep 15:00; Mon 5 Oct 14:30

Juste avant la nuit

Just before Nightfall
Tue 8 Sep 20:45; Sun 27 Sep 12:10; Fri 2 Oct 14:30

Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 18:10 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Mon 21 Sep 20:50;
Fri 25 Sep 20:45; Sun 4 Oct 12:20; Tue 6 Oct 14:30

Philosophical Screens: Le Boucher

Wed 9 Sep 20:10 Blue Room

Wedding in Blood

Les noces rouges
Thu 10 Sep 18:10; Tue 15 Sep 21:00;
Tue 29 Sep 18:20

Ten Days' Wonder

La décade prodigieuse
Thu 10 Sep 20:30 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley); Sat 19 Sep 18:10

La Femme infidèle

The Unfaithful Wife
From Fri 11 Sep (Preview screening on
Tue 1 Sep 20:30)

Violette Nozière

Sun 20 Sep 18:00 (+ intro by academic Catherine Dousteyssier-Khoze); Wed 30 Sep 20:30

The Hatter's Ghost

Les fantômes du chapelier
Tue 22 Sep 18:00; Mon 28 Sep 20:35

The Cry of the Owl

Le cri du hibou
Tue 22 Sep 20:55; Mon 28 Sep 18:00

Mean Girls: Claude Chabrol's Dangerous Women

Wed 23 Sep 18:15

The Swindle

Rien ne va plus
Fri 25 Sep 18:15; Sat 3 Oct 18:15 (+ intro by Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

The Colour of Lies

Au coeur du mensonge
Sat 26 Sep 15:00; Sun 4 Oct 15:10

Story of Women

Une affaire de femmes
Sat 26 Sep 17:50; Thu 1 Oct 20:30

La Cérémonie

Thu 1 Oct 18:00 (+ extended intro on queer Chabrol by academic Kit Francis Bradbury Rance);
Tue 6 Oct 20:45

The Bridesmaid

La demoiselle d'honneur
Sat 3 Oct 15:10; Mon 5 Oct 20:40 (+ intro by season curator Catherine Wheatley)

The Girl Cut in Two

La fille coupée en deux
Sat 3 Oct 20:40; Tue 6 Oct 18:00 (+ Q&A with Claude Chabrol's daughter and collaborator Cécile Maistre-Chabrol)

With thanks to

Tamasa Distribution

The BFI will be releasing a selection of
Claude Chabrol's films on Blu-ray and DVD in 2027

house – like his paisley shirts, his Black au pair girl, his refusal to own a car – is a token of nonconformity, built on his naive theory that ‘un peu d’avant-garde au tour de soi évite la sclérose.’ But as he gradually discovers, it is in no sense a structure which can accommodate the enormous eccentricity of his act.

The sight of his wife and children, his idolising mother's remarks about Laura's patent immorality, the rituals of Christmas and family life, heighten Charles' sense of his own unworthiness and stimulate in him a desire to be judged by his peers. But just as he, to the rage of his camp business partner, will refuse to judge the ‘faithful’ accountant who absconds with the office payroll, so they politely accept his act as a momentary aberration and refuse to modify their opinion of him. Craving rejection, Charles proceeds miserably from one confession to the next, only to be offered absolution rather than punishment. Héléne receives the news of his liaison with a ‘mon pauvre chéri, comme tu as dû souffrir’; François learns that his best friend murdered his wife, observes sympathetically that no one is guilty of what happens in a nightmare, and that he'll drop by tomorrow as usual. In vain does Charles protest that ‘je ne peux pas supporter de ne pas être jugé.’ Neither Héléne nor François will be drawn into the game of crime and punishment which only Laura understood.

Héléne will, of course, eventually make the decisive play, but only after her uncomprehending and antiseptic sympathy has subtly provided the spectator with some justification for Charles' at first sight monstrous act. Yet what makes the film's ending so unusually chilling is that Héléne herself, unlike her namesake in *Le Boucher*, recognises no connection between her own ‘virtue’ and her partner's vice, indeed persistently refuses to acknowledge that the vice exists. Even when she kills Charles, it is not to satisfy his lust for punishment but rather, by preventing him from going to the police, to keep his darker reality from leaving any permanent stain on her ideal home. The final sequence, with its layers of duplicity, offers a bleak view of the foundations on which such homes are built. Protesting that she understands and admires Charles' desire to do what is right, Héléne cold-bloodedly administers an overdose of laudanum; and he, secretly aware of what she's done but believing that she has done it for him, at last falls asleep in childlike contentment, clasping the hand of his ‘model’ wife as they lie side by side in their separate beds.

Jan Dawson, *Sight and Sound*, Spring 1973